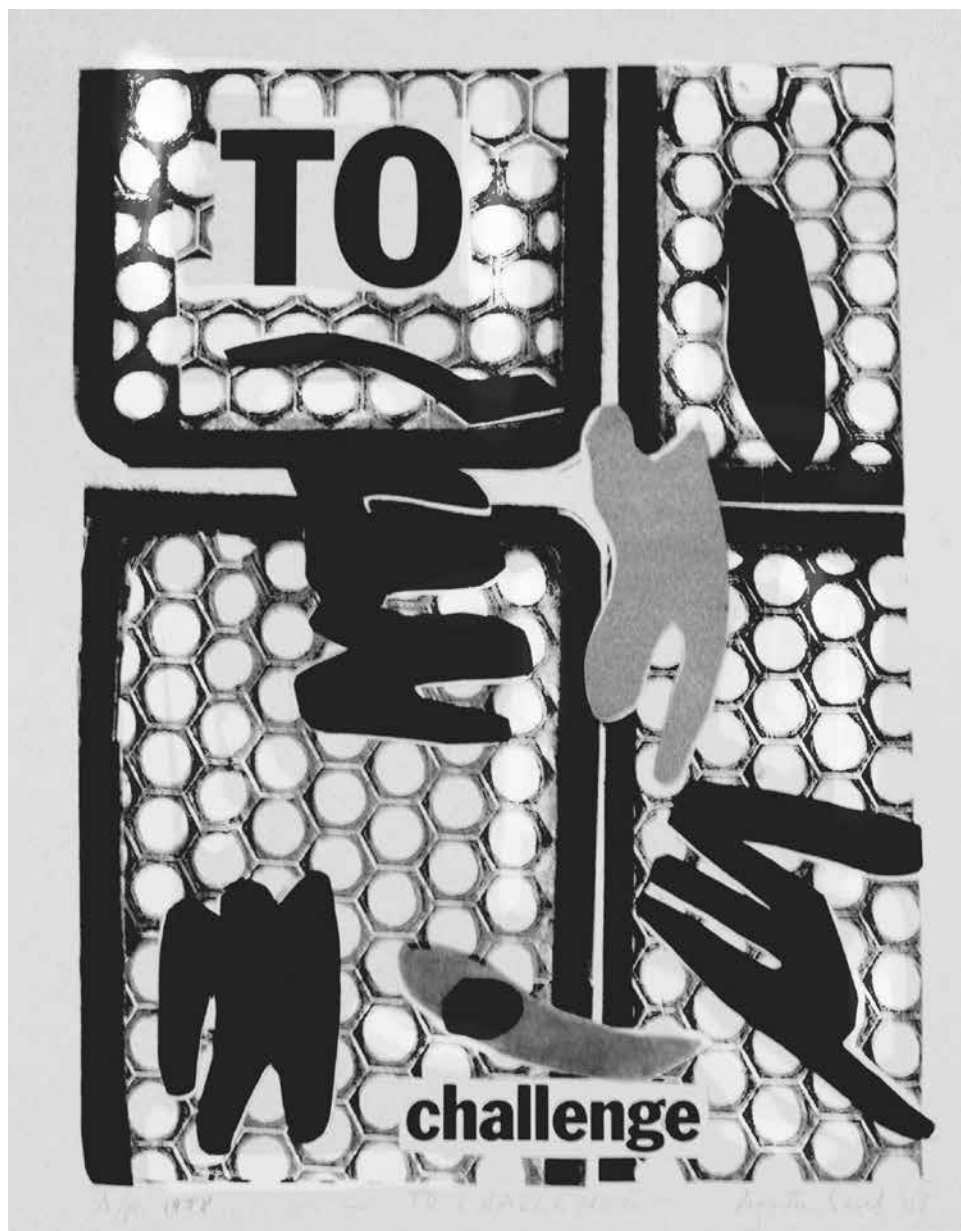




Agathe Sorel, *To Challenge*, digital print and woodcut in colour, 2005

Chapter 4: America

I travelled to the USA yearly from 1960-1975 and was totally fascinated by the liveliness and variety of the landscape, the people and especially the artists I met.

My first visit was to Philadelphia in 1960, where I received generous help and backing from the Print Club with Bertha von Moschizker at its helm and artists who were involved with their projects. I then continued to New Orleans, Mexico, Arizona, the Grand Canyon, Los Angeles, San Francisco, Iowa, Chicago and New York. I visited art colleges and museums and was able to interview significant artists and scientists who influenced my work. 5 years later, the award of a grant from the Winston Churchill Memorial Trust allowed me to visit the country once more.

Bertha von Moschizker

My travels in the USA often started in Philadelphia, where the Print Club and its Director Bertha von Moschizker provided a friendly base. It was her father who first founded the Print Club and he was the first director and had the foresight to start a space with exceptional facilities for aspiring printmakers at a time when modern prints were hardly being shown in museums and art galleries. There was an imaginative educational program manned by volunteers travelling the state in a van equipped with all the facilities, reaching even the poorest areas. The talent available was quite amazing and the most important artists of the time joined the team.

After her father's death Bertha von Moschizker became the second director of the gallery. She was a wealthy woman and did not accept a salary. The Print Club was also helped by her brother, who was even wealthier. I had the luck to befriend two artists involved with the project, Sam Maitin and Warrington Colescott with whom we kept in touch for many years and exchanged houses.



Sam Maitin

Left: Sam Maita, *Zeus*, mixed media intaglio plate, 1965

Right: John Donne poster poem, 1965

Sam Maitin

Sam Maitin was a most versatile artist. As well as his prints for which he was best known, his work could also be seen in the streets as monumental sculpture, stained glass and murals, but also on shopping bags, posters and banners. In his studio was a large etching press, facilities for silk screen and his main love, a collection of artists' books.

His Georgian house on Pine Street was arranged over 5 floors in what was then an unfashionable working class district but is now is now extremely classy, and every level was furnished in a different style and had a different function. The basement level was long and pretty dark and was filled with the finds from flea markets across the world. This is where his work table lay. How he managed to create the most beautiful and simple artwork in this chaos is hard to imagine.





Sam used to say that “the business of art is to play with form, shape and colour”. He was influenced by Matisse, Miro, and Chagall. He had attended workshops run by Bill Hayter for the Philadelphia Print Club during the war. He produced large scale abstract prints using a variety of techniques

He was a most generous host and we stayed in his house on several occasions, coming and going quite freely. He introduced us to his best contacts, such as the museum director, Ding McNulty. He also introduced me to the wealthy collector Lessing Rosenwald, who bought some of my prints, leaving them for the Library of Congress after his death. Lessing allowed us free access to his fabulous collection of early German woodcuts, which was his real passion. Sam allowed us to use his natty sports car to get around, which allowed us to visit Bela Kalman and his wife Edna in their house in Boston and on Cape Cod.

Sam had issues with his body image. He was a bespectacled little Jewish man, pale, with bad posture and he wanted to escape that image. He started on a body building program and special diet with the most spectacular results. To everyone’s great surprise, he became a broad-shouldered muscle man. In 1968, when he came to stay in our house in Irene Road in Fulham, the great change has already taken place. He came to London on a Guggenheim fellowship and worked at the Curwen Press with Stanley Jones.

The Tate Gallery has acquired some of his work which is now also represented in many Museums and universities and achieves impressive auction prices. He died at the age of 76 in 2004. We miss him greatly as obviously, he still had a lot to give.

**Sam Maitan, 50' Mural
for children's hospital,
mixed media, 1991**
photo Seymour Mednick

Warrington Colescott

Warrington Colescott was also very involved in the Print Club. He was born in Oakland, California, in 1921 to parents of Louisiana Creole descent. He was a rare talent and innovator in the print field.

He specialized in bawdy satires in the best tradition of Daumier and Gillray, but using contemporary settings and also influenced by the comic books he loved in his youth. His plates combine collage, cut-out cardboard prints, etching and silkscreen as well as the more traditional etching techniques. They are a riot and still feel very contemporary.

He studied at the University of California, Berkley, gaining a degree in 1942 before serving in the US military. After the War, he went back to his studies and earned a teaching certificate. In 1949, he began his career at the University of Wisconsin-Madison where he remained for 37 years until his retirement. During those years, Colescott continued his education in Europe, first in 1952–53 on the GI Bill to study at the Académie de la Grande Chaumière, Paris, when he also worked with Bill Hayter. In 1956–57, he was a Fulbright Fellow at the Slade School of Fine Art, University of London, and in 1963, he returned to London on a Guggenheim Fellowship. It was in 1957 that we met him when he lived in our house in Irene Road and worked with Anthony Gross at the Slade and Stanley Jones at the Curwen Press where he also had an exhibition.

He gave us two magnificent prints. One, *Dream of a Print Collector* of 1968 is a signed colour etching. The images he uses



Warrington Colescott

Warrington Colescott,
*Dream of a Print
Collector*, colour
etching, 1968





Warrington Colescott,
Patriotics, color intaglio
on paper, 1969



Warrington
Colescott, Lunch with
Lautrec, from the
series *A History of
Printmaking*, color
intaglio on paper, 1977

in this work were drawn from prints by Gauguin, Toulouse Lautrec, Picasso, Dubuffet, Beckmann and Goya. The second print, entitled *Patriotics* and dated 1969, attacks the false patriotism of the Establishment, showing the Ku Klux Klan, FBI agents and an armed goat trampling on symbols of family and country.

Leonard Baskin

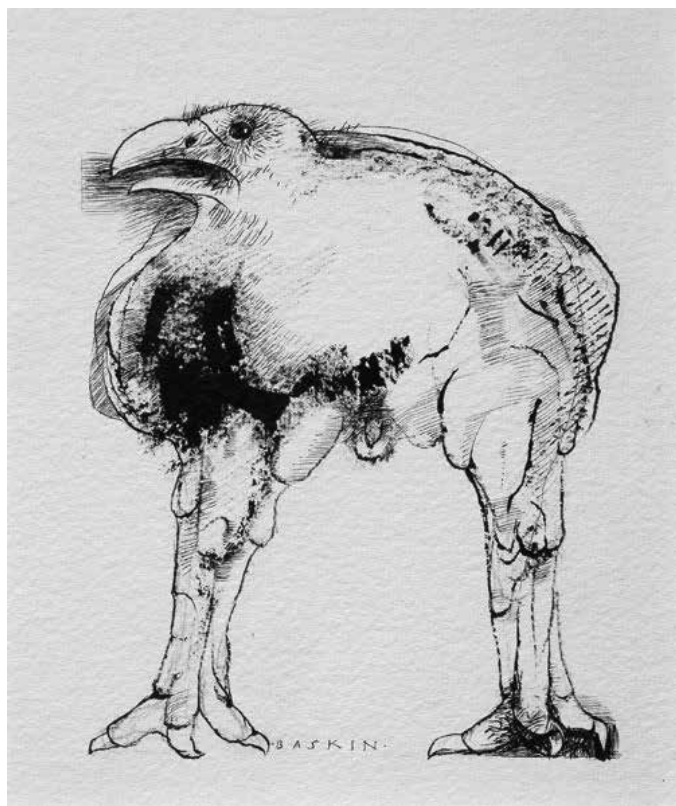
I met Baskin in during my travels. He had recently exhibited with the Philadelphia Print Club and also taught at Smith College, where I had been invited to lecture. I had admired his work for a long time. He lived in England for 9 years from 1974 to 1983 and provided illustrations for his close friend Ted Hughes' book *Crow*.



Leonard Baskin, self portrait, woodcut, 1959

He worked in painting and sculpture as well as creating marvellous artist's books. He stuck to figurative art, when most other American artists turned to abstraction. He was a highly-cultured man, son of a rabbi who was interested in philosophy and all the big moral questions.

I visited him in Northampton Massachusetts, where he owned a large forest and a rather sprawling open plan house. Huge logs of timber were standing propped up in his yard. I think they were redwood, which is very hard and thereby



Leonard Baskin, *Crow*, drawing, 1971



Leonard Baskin,
The Trabismic Jew,
woodcut, 1962

easy to carve. The logs were cut in half vertically, so that he could work on them with his chisels as if they were wood engravings. This was a different method from Michael Rothenstein and Tadek Beutlich who used horizontal slices accentuating the grain of the wood. The monumental carvings were most impressive.

In the house, he sat me down and showed me his inspiring books. There was a rather strange atmosphere, as his wife lay in bed at the back-bedroom raving and ranting. She suffered from Multiple Sclerosis and was in great pain. His young girlfriend, Lisa Unger, a former student, later his second wife helped to look after her and gave us tea. His young son, about 8 years old, was clearly upset. Nevertheless, he insisted that he wanted to look after his

Leonard Baskin, Spies on his enemies - Crow, drawing, 1972



wife and would not send her to an institution. She died a year later, shortly after he divorced her to marry Lisa.

At the table I showed him my portfolio of *Le Balcon* and he was interested in the way I portrayed characters, showing a different take on figuration. At this point a spider crossed the table and he pondered over the moral dilemma of whether to kill it or to save a life.

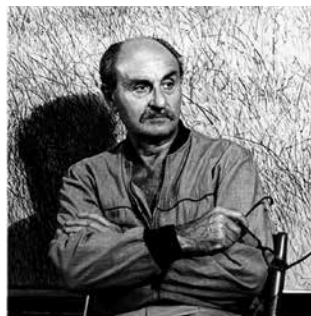
He offered me one of his prints, which I stupidly did not accept on the grounds that I had not done anything to deserve such a valuable gift.

Gabor Peterdi

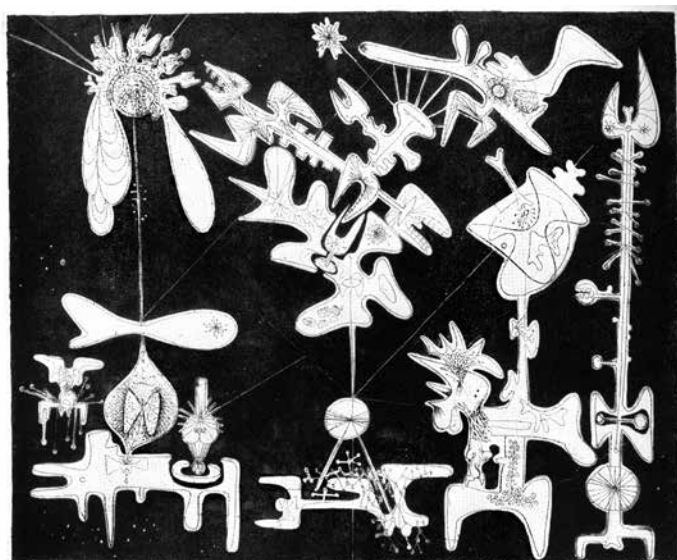
We first met Gabor and his wife through an introduction from Bertha von Moschizker and Bill Hayter. He lived in his large sprawling house and studio near the sea in Connecticut within commuting distance of the University of Yale where he was a professor. He and his family had emigrated from Hungary in 1939. His mother was a friend of the renowned poet Margit Kaffka. Most people in Hungary are familiar with her poem *Petike Walks* with its touching description of the first hesitant steps of a baby. I had always assumed that this was a description of her own baby but in fact recently learnt that it was describing the baby of a friend.

By the time we met, he was in his early sixties, bald and moustachioed, and a very famous man. I knew his book *Printmaking: Methods Old and New* well. It is concise without too much theory, an absolute bible for both the first initiated and teachers of the discipline. I used it together with Hayter's *New Ways of Gravure* for my induction classes.

Although Peterdi's work clearly shows the influence of Hayter with whom he worked both in Paris and New York, he developed a style of his own. I was immediately impressed by some huge canvases in his studio which showed a riot of colours. He worked at the high tide of Abstract Expressionism, but his pictures were

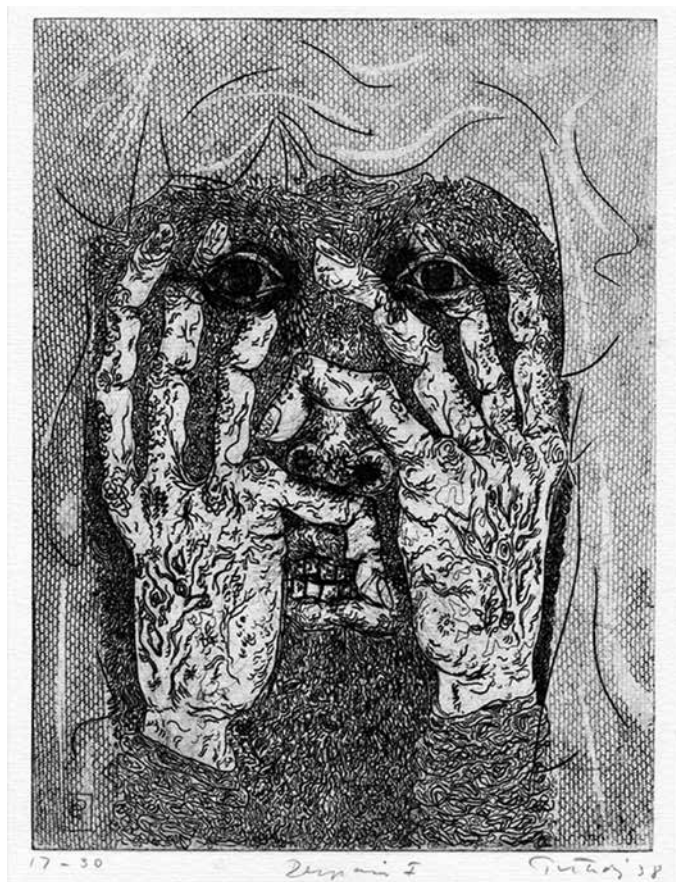


Gabor Peterdi



Gabor Peterdi, *Dark Visit*, relief etching, 1948

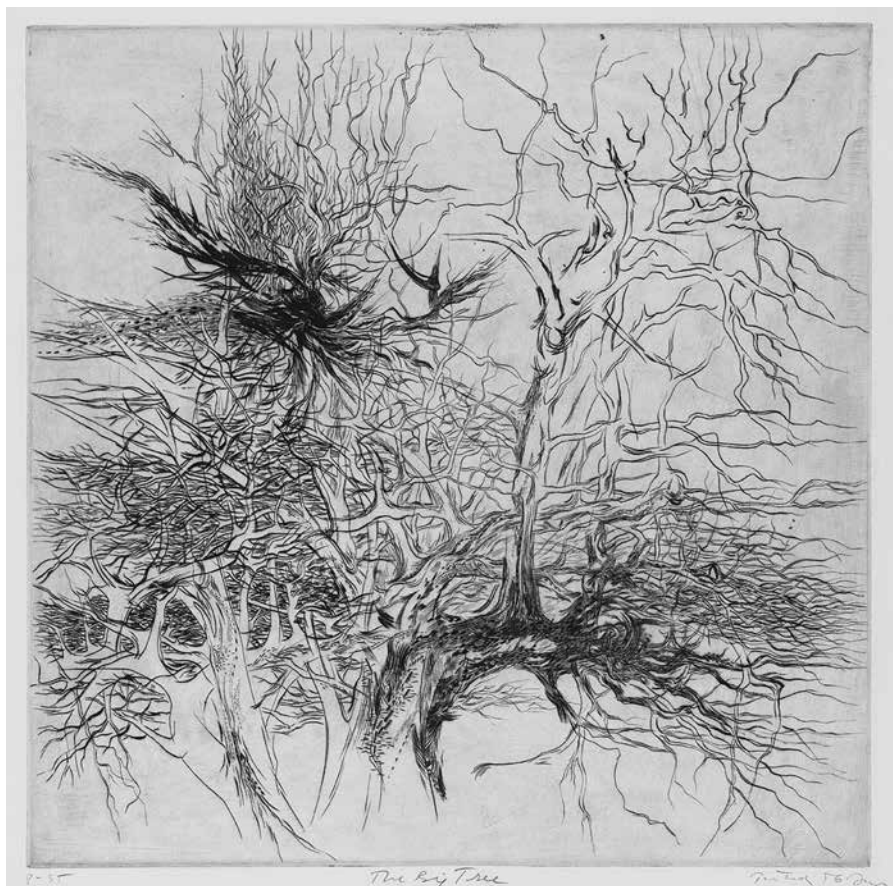
Gabor Peterdi, *Despair*
1, Soft ground etching,
1938



always rooted in a degree of realism and show an acute interest in the natural world.

He started painting early and exhibited from the age of 15 when he won the prestigious Prix de Rome. When exhibiting in Paris, Picasso saw his work and said: "Young man, you have talent, but now you must learn to draw". He took this advice very seriously. He had many students working and helping out in his studio, who are now very famous artists themselves. He always printed his editions himself.

We were invited to his house several times. It was quite stunning to see his works in the original as they were so much bigger and more vividly coloured than I had imagined. At one of these dinner parties, another guest, also from Hungary and a textile designer



took a great liking to my black and white Jaeger knit dress with its shocking pink silk collar and demanded that I take it off and give it to him so he could work out how the dress had been constructed. I refused!

We later heard that his wife had died. He was devastated as he absolutely relied on her. Some years later, he was introduced to a lady, a widow almost 30 years younger and they hit it off immediately. They came to see us in London and had a Hungarian dinner, a very pleasant evening and exchange of ideas in my studio house in Wilton Row, comparing notes of a similar background and influences. He died in 2001 at the age of 86, working to the end.

**Gabor Peterdi, *Big Tree*,
intaglio, 1957**

The Winston Churchill Memorial Trust

The Winston Churchill Memorial Trust was set up on 1st February 1965, the day after Churchill's funeral, to 'perpetuate and honour the memory of Sir Winston Churchill' by administering the award of Travelling Fellowships known as a Churchill Fellowship. The aim was to give 'men and women from all walks of life' the opportunity of travel and research; to gain global insight, put into practice innovative ideas, to create valuable networks abroad and thereby contribute to the community. Money was raised by the public in general, and people gave generously.

My mother saw an advertisement in *The Times* and encouraged me to apply. There were several categories and I applied as an artist-educator. I was interviewed by a large panel chaired by Lord Mountbatten, Director General at the time. I was selected from over 800 applicants. I had already made some trips to the USA and decided that I would like to spend more time there visiting art colleges and learning from their teaching methods.

I travelled around the USA and Mexico for six months during 1966-67, making useful contacts and carrying out research. It was a life changing experience. The time presently allocated is just four weeks. The grant was extremely generous and allowed a reasonable lifestyle. I had to report back to the committee every month and Lord Mountbatten was amused and impressed by my adventures and allowed me to change my brief from visiting art colleges, to studying museums and their displays. I found the art colleges very traditional and rather old fashioned and so swapped to museums, which then struck me as a far more interesting area of research. Their ideas on display and education I found fascinating and were very new and different to what was going on in Europe at the time. For example, there was a fountain in front of the Philadelphia museum which attracted children to the premises, and organised treasure hunts to attract younger visitors.

The Administrator of the Churchill Trust, Anne Seagrim, became a lifelong friend. She took up painting and when she retired, she applied for a fellowship herself to allow her to visit Australia and Hong Kong. She was tireless in keeping the community of Fellows together so that they could profit from each other's experience.

Lord Mountbatten was assassinated by the IRA in 1979 when his boat was blown up by the IRA. He, his mother-in-law, his 14-year old grandson and a 15-year old deckhand died. He was a favourite cousin of the Queen, uncle of the Duke of Edinburgh and the last Viceroy of India.

Charlie Kanev and the plastics factory

We were introduced to Charlie by a friend in Philadelphia during our stay in Sam Maitin's house. We were told he was an unusual character, wealthy and a patron of the arts. They thought we must go to see his factory which was indeed spectacular; it looked like it came straight out of a cubist painting, with parts of machinery picked out with white paint while the rest with its metallic tone reinforced the functionality.

The factory fabricated parts of air crafts and gears combining Lucite with carbon fibre.

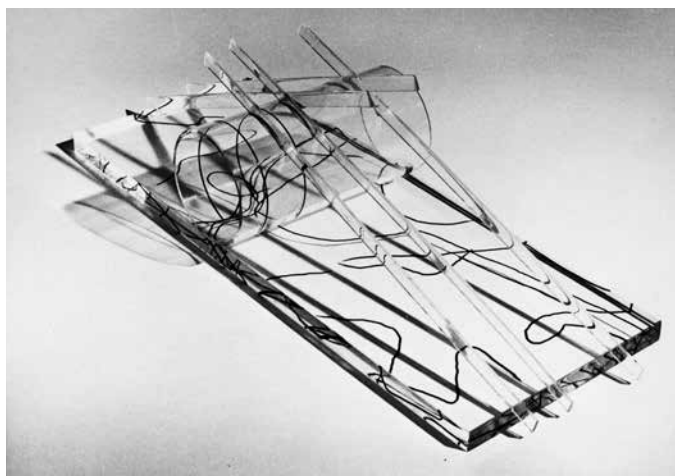
Charlie showed me how to work on acrylics and gave me enough material to get on with, when I got back to England as well as a super-fast router which I still use for engraving in spite of the fact that more modern versions which have come onto the market since. We became friends of the family, a link which is still alive and I am still in contact with his widow Miriam, who at 96, still active and beautiful and continues to live independently as well as his son Paul, a brain surgeon, who is a patron of the arts.

Charlie was born in Philadelphia. His parents came from the Ukraine near Kiev and had an arranged marriage, meeting for the first time under the chuppah. They wanted to come to the USA for a better life and prospects in spite of the fact that they knew nobody there. No doubt the growing antisemitism and pogroms must have also been a factor.

Once in the USA Charlie's father started manufacturing machines for trimming wallpaper and when he died in 1941, Charlie, who

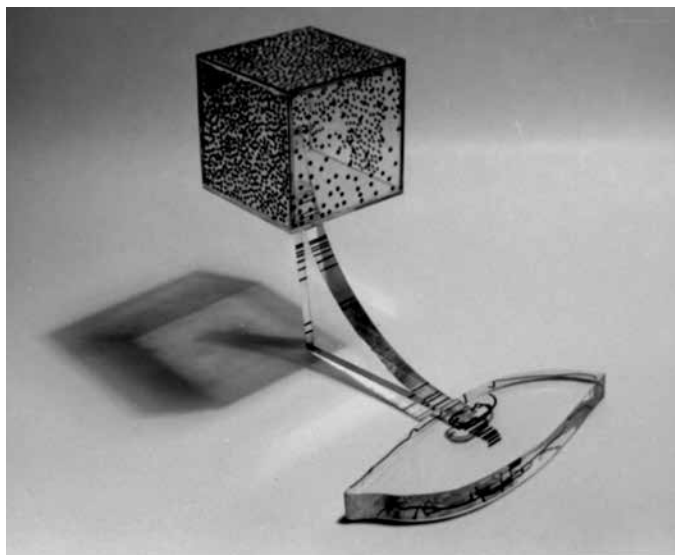


Charlie Kanev



Agathe Sorel, Raft, acrylic sculpture made out of material bought from Philadelphia, 1968

Agathe Sorel, *Inner Lights* Acrylic, sculpture made out of material bought from Philadelphia, 1968



was the youngest of three children, took over the business. He was soon drafted into the navy and after the war moved back to the manufacturing sector but with a difference. He pioneered the manufacturing and industrial use of Lucite, known as Perspex in the UK. He had no formal education as he started work when he was 13 years old, but while running his business he completed his education at night school.

He began summer studies in an art school in Philadelphia and near his house near Atlantic City, where he found an excellent teacher, also from Russia. He worked in wax and plaster, but soon moved onto marble. He worked with a sculptor near the marble quarries in Carrara Italy and, true to style and entrepreneurial spirit, he imported 60 tons of Carrara marble to his house and studio. At his death in 1995 there were still 5 tons left unused.

My meeting with Charlie was pivotal to my career as when I returned to London I began experimenting with working in Perspex and created my Space Engravings.

The pieces illustrated here are from the materials I brought back from Philadelphia.

New York

When I first stayed in New York, the first hotel I found was cheap with clientele who were mostly retired or divorced people, supplementing their modest income by speculating on the stock exchange and putting bids on gilts, stocks or shares. They watched a television monitor with the continuously changing rates with a beady eye all day and did not say a word to anyone.

An even cheaper version was staying in bog standard hotels, with virtually no amenities, and this is what our well liked nude model from England rented out. He was Quentin Crisp "The Naked Civil Servant". He was openly gay at a time when this was almost a crime and suffered violent attacks and abuse. He had an extravagant style of clothing, with heavy makeup, a wide brimmed velour hat and a long scarf and Edwardian costume. After the publication of his book and the successful film in which he played himself, he retired to New York to this type of hotel, in a room no bigger than a shoebox and was blissfully happy until he died.

https://youtu.be/e7L7_qIGCo8 QUENTIN CRISP VIDEO

New Orleans

The next stop on my US tour was New Orleans. In 1968, New Orleans was in its full glory. The architecture was in the French colonial style, the elegant houses with their white stucco finish all had elaborate wrought iron balconies. There were theatres and concerts, and almost daily festivals with processions of floats and jazz bands playing the latest New Orleans tunes marching down the streets in colourful costumes. Everyone joined in, black and white, including the local museum director, who was a great fan. I managed to get a room in a hotel in the middle of the city, not realising it was in the red-light district.

One evening, I went for a walk along Royal Street and Bourbon Street where numerous strip clubs and dance studios lined both sides of the street. The doors were wide open, so the punters passing by in open cars could see exactly what they were getting before deciding where to spend their money.

Walking in this rather insalubrious and somewhat dangerous neighbourhood, my eyes were suddenly caught by an apparition; in the window of a little bookshop. There was a terracotta head from the Mayan civilization hung high upon the wall, lit by a single spotlight. I have never seen anything so compellingly beautiful and disturbing before.

I returned the following morning to meet the owner of the antiquarian bookshop, Larry Borenstein, a Talmudic scholar who



Pre columbian pottery head



had a whole collection of Pre-Columbian artefacts. This comprised mainly of pottery figurines which were sitting on the floor of his bookshop, the mud only partially removed. The beauty and originality of these pieces, some of which dated back almost 1500 years, filled me with awe and admiration.

Obtaining and importing such material was against the law in Mexico, and could have resulted in a stiff prison sentence. Nevertheless, I heard how in stormy and wet weather in the winter, lorries were dispatched through the unguarded border to pick up yellow earth from the mud slides near the known architectural sites. These pieces were then found in amongst the mud.

They were then deposited to the floor of the gallery, awaiting museum curators and other collectors to visit. I simply fell in love with these figures and decided to buy some.

Leonora Carrington

Unknown to me at this time Larry, who lived in the suburbs with his family, was sheltering Leonora Carrington, the Surrealist painter and writer. It was the time of the 1968 student revolts and when students had demonstrated against the right-wing government in Mexico City, she had marched with them bringing her two sons along. She had run a printing press from her home, printing anti-government literature and when there was a danger that she might be arrested, she had fled to New Orleans alone, leaving her husband and sons behind. Apparently, she hated flying and wore a life jacket for the whole plane journey. She eventually returned to Mexico City.

<https://youtu.be/lqXePrSE1Ro> you tube video



Leonora Carrington
and Max Ernst

I would later meet Leonora myself. She came from a respectable and wealthy middle class British family and had even been a debutante. She left her convent school early and went to Paris, where she got involved with the Surrealist movement. She was gifted and original both as a painter and a writer and André Breton the surrealist's main theorist and advocate thought she was a child



Leonora Carrington,
*Self Portrait (Inn of the
Dawn Horse)*, oil on
canvas, 1937



Leonora Carrington,
Evening Conference,
oil on canvas, 1949

genius. She was also very pretty and many members of the group fell in love with her. Her relationship with Max Ernst was the most significant and they collaborated and helped each other while living together in the south of France. When the Nazis occupied France, Ernst was arrested even though he was a German, gentile, tall and blond because his art was considered degenerate. He managed to escape both the Nazis and France, leaving for the United States where he married the rich heiress and patron of the arts Peggy Guggenheim.

In his absence, Leonora escaped to Spain and afterwards to Portugal where she had a nervous breakdown. She was treated with rather drastic drugs, which are now banned. She took refuge in the Mexican Embassy in Lisbon where the ambassador, Renato Leduc agreed to marry her to allow her to escape Europe. The two of them travelled to Mexico where she settled happily, divorcing Leduc soon after. She then married the Hungarian photographer Imre Weisz with whom she had two sons.

We met her in Paris in 1969 at her solo exhibition and in 1991 in London when this exhibition was shown at the Serpentine Gallery. The collector Edward James bought many of her works, rightly considering that she was an important English Surrealist, although she lived in Mexico City until her death in 2011

One month in Mexico

After one month in the USA, I crossed the border into Mexico. My travels in that beautiful country brought me countless memorable adventures and many of my paintings, photographs and prints show the lasting inspiration provided by this trip.

Whilst detailed description of the remarkable archaeological sites can be found elsewhere, I would like to introduce a few more remarkable characters that I met during my month of travels.

Trudy Blom was a Swiss archaeologist whom I met in San Cristóbal de las Casas in Chiapas, Mexico. She and her husband Franz converted a derelict colonial monastery into a beautiful home, calling it Nabolom, which translates as 'the House of the Jaguar'.

Trudy and Franz had a government grant to map and document the area. They had opened their home to the public as a guest house, museum and research centre, organising trips to the jungle and lectures in archaeology and cooking. Trudy was later recognized as a national treasure, but at the time of my visit, shortly after the death of her husband, she was struggling to make ends meet.

Trudy took me on a couple of expeditions to photograph and record the little known Lacandon Indians. She fitted her mules with traditional Mexican wooden saddles and we rode up the most hair-raising paths to hidden villages high up in the mountains. The steep trails were more suitable for goats than mules and I, who had never mounted a horse before, hung on to the large wooden knob of the saddle for dear life.

I took many photos and literally drunk with colour, attempted to make some watercolours. When we arrived up in the hills, an annual fiesta was taking place amongst the looming clouds. People from nearby villages arrived, covered with blue plastic sheeting to shelter themselves from the rain, to take part in the half pagan, half Christian festivities. Their religion was a symbiosis of ancient Mayan beliefs and Roman Catholicism. They had a fanciful interpretation of their history which was difficult for outsiders to comprehend. They danced the Cortez dance in their colourful costumes, impersonating horses and cavaliers while in the supposedly Christian church a magician preached with a mirror on his hat, reading signs from the birds. All the colourful textiles at the festivities were spun and woven with primitive wooden looms by local women. These were mostly waist looms, when woman actually sat in the waft the other end of the wool was attached or hung from a tree.

Trudy told me her life story. Born in Switzerland, she had studied journalism and social work. In the mid-1930s she went to Germany to report on Hitler's atrocities for her magazine and also joined the socialist party. She was arrested in France as a member of the resistance and deported back to Switzerland. She was lucky, it could have been worse. At that point, she decided to go to New York to raise funds for the refugees, but on the ship changed her mind and went to Mexico instead, where she met her husband Franz Blom.

After my stay in her house we corresponded and Trudy sent me her cookbook, which I still use regularly. She died in 1969 aged 92.

Doña Rosa

I went to see the famous archaeological site of Monte Alban and the nearest town with a reasonable hotel was Oaxaca. In the morning, I went to explore the markets.

The fresh fruit and vegetable stalls were a riot of colours, but there were also several rows of stalls selling textiles, wood carvings and pottery. The most popular exhibits were the inexpensive reproductions of small figurines of the Zapotecan culture, dating from roughly 6th century BC. They were not high quality, being manufactured locally for the tourists.

After rows and rows of these rather commercial products, there was a stall, which caught my eyes; the pieces were outstanding, made by a true artist. To talk about stalls is probably misleading, as the pieces were spread along the ground, sometimes displayed on woven blankets.

There were small figurines of animals, angels looking like mermaids, whistles; all made with great observation and character out of the traditional polished black clay. There were also monumental sculptural pieces which, with their sleek black forms, reminded me of the work of the famous Romanian sculptor Brancusi

I was told that these pieces were made by Doña Rosa, a very old lady, who lived in a nearby village and never came to town. I decided to meet her and took a taxi to her village. There were a few mud huts in the desert and a strange circular contraption, where they fired the pottery. A very ancient wrinkled figure sat on the ground and used two saucers as a potter's wheel. Turning these with her feet, she built up sculptural shapes from coiled clay, smoothing

Doña Rosa, Clay pot,
1968



them with wet hands both from the inside and the outside. She had an absolute sureness of touch and invented new shapes all the time.

I was sure that I had met a remarkable artist.

When a number of pots were ready and dry, they took them to the circular sand pit to be fired. They burned seven different timbers during the process of firing and the smoke was pumped to the centre, where the pots were lined up covered with sand. I believe the procedure lasted seven hours and then the pots were allowed to cool down gradually.

They were then taken out and polished to a high shine until they looked like bullets or objects from outer space. I bought as many as I could and asked them to pack them up for me. They found me a woven reed basket with a lid, and wrapped the ceramics into rags and old newspapers.

It was dispatched to England in a cargo boat, and arrived in perfect condition after three months at sea. They now occupy prime positions in my studio and the woven basket lies under my press.

The Padre of Zihuatanejo

I moved onto Acapulco, which did not like at all in spite of the gorgeous views. It was modern and commercialized, a millionaire's playground and a tourist trap. Whilst there, I heard about the remote coastal village of Zihuatanejo and decided to go there instead. I took a local bus through the jungle, which was crammed with local people wearing one hat on top of another. This was for good reason, as their chickens were sitting up above our heads on the shelves and the hats protected them from the droppings. There were goats lying down tied up in the aisle, so it was hardly possible to move. The jungle was beginning to dry out in that season and giant iguanas sat by the road with beady eyes, who knows what they were waiting for? The peasants, who wanted to make sure to catch the bus and not be left behind, simply lay across the road face down, their heads covered with their hats. The relatively short journey lasted for several hours as a result.

Finally, we arrived to a small village, consisting of a few mud huts, a church and an inn.

The beach was idyllic, with a few palm trees and golden sand and I had it almost completely to myself. I was looking in vain for a hotel or guest house, but there was none available, the village was used by day-trippers only who arrived and returned to civilization using helicopters or small aircraft.

In desperation, I asked advice at the inn and they directed me to the Padre in the nearby Catholic Church. He took me in and very kindly offered the only habitable room up in the church tower, with splendid views over the beach. When I opened a little window, which gave me a view into the church, I could see rather surprised people in the congregation and paintings of little putti flying around under the rafters. I had a blissfully comfortable night, and used the primitive washstand and water which was prepared for me. I was just tidying up in the morning, when the padre came up to ask how I was. I asked him what to do with the dirty water in the bucket as I didn't want to leave this work for him. No problem, he said and poured the whole lot into the street, where it was promptly absorbed in the dust.

I spent the day on the beach painting, but in the evening the Padre prepared a very special treat for me downstairs in his own kitchen. He made a bean stew with pigs' ears in a big cauldron and took it over to the inn to be warmed up, and this is where we ate it.

He also took me to a dressmaker, who lived in a mud hut with a thatched roof, to have some alterations made on a garment which I bought in the village... The lady had an ancient Singer sewing machine, which she used with great skill. The mud hut had no flooring, just red earth all around, with black piglets roaming around inside and out. It could have come from a painting by Gauguin.

When the time came to say goodbye, the Padre called a taxi to take me to the airport. There was no runway, just a dirt track that could only be used by helicopters and small two seater aircraft.

Once in the taxi, we found that it would not go forwards, so we went in reverse all the way to the airport, it seemed that only the reverse gear was working. By then I took these strange things in my stride.

A somewhat similar situation emerged when I visited La Venta Park, the famous Olmec archaeological site where you can see giant heads and other sculpture from 1200-900 BC.

As there is no quarry with this type of stone anywhere nearby, it is still a mystery how these primitive people managed to drag these stones from a great distance without the use of the wheel.

From there I wanted to visit Palenque and other historic sites in the jungle and the only option seemed to be to hire a helicopter, which was very expensive, or a small two seater aircraft, where the propeller had to be started off by hand. So, this is what I chose; the two seats were one behind the other. The pilot must have wanted some fun or else he was drunk as he sat in the back

seat and gave the controls to me, giving instructions in Spanish, occasionally adjusting buttons reaching forward by hand. Unfortunately, my Spanish was very poor at the time and I was absolutely terrified, especially at the landings. Again, there were no runways whatsoever, only grass meadows, where laconic cows, obviously used to small aircraft landing near them all the time, just stood their ground. Needless to say, I had never piloted an aircraft before and never have since.

Whilst visiting the famous ruins of Chichen Itza, I stayed in the nearby town of Merida possibly the ugliest of subtropical towns. However, the hotel was able to hire a jeep for me to explore the neighbouring countryside. A battered open jeep arrived the following morning, with Juan, the driver, who assured me, that his vehicle was able to cross the jungle and he made this trip a couple of times a week.

The jeep was indeed special as in the bottom there was a heavy piece of metal, like the keel of a boat, which could be tilted either way, if the balance of the vehicle became precarious. It was used quite often during the trip. Juan had to cut down the vegetation with his machete quite often to be able to proceed and I was getting quite car sick when the jeep had to mount some seemingly impossible obstacles. Juan was quite prepared. From the back of the car he produced a bucket with ice and coca cola with a bottle of rum and I helped myself with some regularity to strengthen my resolve. By the time we arrived to the ruins of Uxmal and Yaxchilan and many marvellous smaller sites, overgrown with vegetation I confess I was quite drunk. Nevertheless, I made my best and most unconventional photographs, which I used in my prints on my return.

On the return journey, the tyres of the jeep started to sag and as we had no spares, I thought we were never going to make it. Juan, who was obviously used to the problem stopped frequently and plugged the holes in the tyres with match sticks. Miraculously we managed to get back to the hotel before sunset and I invited Juan to a restaurant to dine with me.

I travelled to many other sites within the month and in Mexico City I was able to visit the newly completed archaeological museum, where I studied the history of the peninsula and began to understand the connections between the various cultures.

<https://youtu.be/kyvw6GgMaxo> Chichen Itza

<https://youtu.be/ouovVVSnUkE>

Yucatan Maya artefacts, sculpture, pottery and design

New York and the Chelsea Hotel

I spent the last month of my Churchill fellowship at the Chelsea Hotel. I was extremely lucky to be able to rent a very large room in this exceptional building, which is described as a New York City landmark. Built in 1883 in the Victorian Gothic Revival style, it is a large brick structure with ornamental cast iron balconies; the inside was most luxurious and typical of the period, a grand lobby with stone floors, marble fireplaces and stained glass windows, dominated by the grand staircase which rises up 12 stories,

It has been colonised by eccentric and notorious artists, who lived there on a permanent basis, so rooms to let for short periods were hard to find. Long-term inhabitants had included the writers Arthur Miller, Dylan Thomas Arthur C Clark, Tennessee Williams and Jack Kerouac (who wrote *On the Road* there), musicians Jimi Hendrix, Edith Piaf and Bob Dylan and artists Larry Rivers, Francesco Clemente, Claes Oldenburg, Willem de Kooning and Andy Warhol, most at very traumatic periods of their lives.

It was, in fact, quite usual for people to live in hotels as property values were so high, that artists could not afford to buy in Manhattan. In the hotels, everything was provided, heating, lighting, room service, bar or restaurants and a lobby where people could meet and discuss topics of interest. The lobby of the Chelsea had many wonderful contemporary paintings, which the management had accepted in lieu of rent.

I had a huge front room at the Chelsea, with a balcony and excellent light, where I was able to work. Next door to me was the studio of Bernard Childs, who ran an art school from his room, with the full knowledge of the management. He covered the floor with canvas, so as not to damage the parquet flooring, bought a dozen or so painting stools and easels and a little podium for the nude models. I think it was one of the best courses in drawing I have witnessed.

I started to work at the print workshop of the famous Pratt Institute, which was nearby, but I was rather disappointed by the lack of amenities and decided to leave printing until I got back to my own workshop in London the following month. It was a joy, however, to explore the area with its special bookshops and restaurants and to visit two noteworthy colleagues from the Atelier 17, who lived within walking distance.

Krishna Reddy rented a huge loft in nearby Greenwich Village, an open space roughly divided in to studio and living space. This area was not as expensive or fashionable at the time as it is today. I think he was a professor at New York University, but insisted

on having his own etching press and other equipment at home entirely under his own control. He was initially a research chemist like Hayter and they worked on the viscosity technique together.

He worked on his etching plates not only with carefully applied acid bites, but with plenty of hand carving and polishing on the zinc or copper plates. They were then rolled up with gentle colours, sometimes eight or ten different tones divided by the amount of oil in each application. It was a miraculous achievement, for which he did have a well-deserved recognition.

Sergio Gonzales Terrero was originally from Chile. He and his wife, who was American, had worked at the Atelier 17 for a couple of years. Sergio did some uncompromisingly abstract art; ploughed up his plates with vertical lines and literally sculpted them without the use of acids. He then rolled them up with layers of colours, probably learnt from Krishna. At the end of their stay in Paris, the couple decided to settle in New York instead of Chile as they thought the USA had the more exciting contemporary art scene. Chile was in any case in political turmoil. Their money soon ran out. All they could afford was a coal cellar, which was not even converted to an apartment. The coal was still there underfoot.

When I visited, they were there with a baby and a toddler, with Sergio working on large editions of prints for a publisher, who must have bought them the large etching press he used. His wife, greatly changed since Paris, was drying the nappies on a clothes line. The space had no windows, just a ventilation hole.

The publisher promised that if Sergio continued printing, he would promote him as an artist and market his work. After a few years, he was as good as his word. Sergio changed his style and began to sell his work. I heard that eventually they were able to move to a nice residential house on the outskirts of Brooklyn and had a reasonably good standard of living.

Mauricio Lasansky

I visited Mauricio on the last leg of my journey round the USA as part of my Churchill Fellowship. I flew from San Francisco over the Rocky Mountains which were covered with snow, accentuated with dramatic shadows. I took in the vastness of space and the loneliness of the university campus of Iowa situated in the heart of agricultural land, an outpost of culture in the middle of practicality and indifference. What a contrast to the lively cultural atmosphere of San Francisco and even Los Angeles! No wonder it was such an important staging post during the recent presidential elections. It was pure Donald Trump country.



Mauricio Lasansky

How did this largely farming community with little interest in culture become the home to a thriving print department, a testimonial to higher ambition and aspiration? Within the large sprawling campus there was an unremarkable modern building housing a well equipped print studio with a small office, where artistic integrity reigned.

Mauricio was aware of the uniqueness of his situation. He had started the only Masters of Art program in printmaking in the USA at the time, where experimentation and uncompromising high standards were aimed for, in defiance of both the commercial gallery world and the conservative old school museum world and

Mauricio Lasansky,
Nacimiento en Cordiel,
engraving, 1958





he was the one to have created it and he continued to defend its integrity.

Mauricio was born in 1914 in Buenos Aires, the son of European Jews. He studied at the Superior School of Fine Arts in his home city before moving to the USA in 1943 as a result of the first of five Guggenheim fellowships that he was awarded. He was offered a post as Visiting Lecturer at the University of Iowa, becoming a full-time member of staff in 1948. He stayed with the University until his retirement and his work is now on indefinite loan to the University Museum.

He was a tireless innovator in the field of intaglio printing, working in a totally original way as he had little contact with the art world for many years. I could appreciate the isolation and desperate longing of his students, who had to travel hundreds of miles to visit museums or see original works of art.

Lasansky had worked with Bill Hayter in the Atelier 17 in New



Mauricio Lasansky, *The Nazi Drawings*, pencil and oil, 1960s

York during the war, but was also influenced by Picasso, El Greco, Modigliani and Chagall.

I knew his work well from reproductions, but what I was not expecting was the sheer size of his prints and the impact of his use of colour. His portraits were life size and all different, no concessions were made to commercial pressures. He sometimes used as many as 50 plates to get the right impact, fitted together like a jigsaw puzzle and he printed the relatively small editions himself, sometimes with the help of students. His aggressively proud behaviour might have seemed immodest, but in a way it was justified.

His best known work was, however, not prints, but his series from 1961-66 entitled *Nazi Drawings* expressing outrage at what had happened during the Holocaust in Europe. These huge drawings were done with pencil and washes or smears of oil paint on paper, thereby rejecting the technical virtuosity of prints, going to the very essence of expression and mark making. This was a powerful testimonial, which was immediately hailed as a masterpiece; it took 3 years to complete. He gave me a signed book, which I often show to my students. It never fails to impress.

Mauricio was very interested in my use of Perspex plates which brings out pure colour. Thin sheets of Perspex could be marked by dry point, mezzotint or scraper, they could not be etched. The plates last for a very long time, almost indefinitely and most importantly the material does not interfere with colour as most metals do owing to chemical interaction. The Royal Mint worked with this method, which was a highly-guarded secret, but I figured it out independently through my work with my acrylic sculpture.

Lasansky is regarded as a giant and father of contemporary print making, whose work brought the media onto the level of fine art; it is shown in many museums all over the world.

<https://youtu.be/n8VmsgC53nA>